

JOINT DECLARATION
by the European Union, on the one hand, and the Government of
Greenland and the Government of Denmark, on the other,
on relations between the European Union and Greenland

The European Union, on the one hand, and the Government of Greenland and the Government of Denmark, on the other, (hereinafter 'the sides')

- guided by the close historical, political, economic and cultural ties between them,
- noting that a strengthening of the relations between the sides has taken place within the period 2007-2013,
- recalling the close and lasting links between the sides that were established by the Treaty amending, with regard to Greenland, the Treaties establishing the European Community¹ in 1985, agreeing that these links should be maintained and confirming that mutual interests should be taken into account by the sides in development of the respective policy agenda of Greenland and 'Europe 2020 – A strategy for smart, sustainable and inclusive growth'²,
- considering that Greenland is a territory remote from the Union with a small population of approximately 57.000 on the world's largest island, facing challenging climatic conditions and a particular social and economic situation resulting from its history and special relationship with Denmark,
- noting that the Council of the European Union agreed on 24 February 2003³ that there is a need to broaden and strengthen future relations between the EU and Greenland, while taking into account the importance of fisheries and structural development problems in Greenland,

¹ OJ L. 29, p. 1, of 1 February 1985.

² COM(2010) 2020

³ Council Conclusions; C/03/52; Brussels, 24 February 2003

- noting that the Act on Greenland Self-Government entered into force on 21 June 2009 replacing the Act on Greenland Home Rule, changing the status of Greenland within the Kingdom of Denmark vesting the Government of Greenland with the authority to assuming new fields of legislative and executive responsibility inter alia in the field of mineral resource activities,
- recalling the geographical links between Europe and Greenland in the North Atlantic and Arctic regions,
- considering that the European Union acknowledges the geostrategic position of Greenland in the Arctic region and the need for a continuation of strong relations between the sides, responding to the global challenges and facilitating cooperation, while supporting the sustainable development of Greenland,
- considering that Greenland and Denmark acknowledge the contribution of strong relations with the European Union and its effect on well-being and economic development of the Greenlandic society, whereby they consider that education and employability is at the core of the support,
- considering, as stipulated in Part IV of the Treaty on the Functioning of the European Union, that Greenland is one of the Overseas Countries and Territories (OCTs) associated with the European Union,
- noting that the maintenance of fishing opportunities for the EU in the Greenland Exclusive Economic Zone, plays an essential part in the proper functioning of the common fisheries policy in the North Atlantic,
- noting that Greenland finds that education and training is a driver for growth in the policy agenda and that education and employability is recognised as a lever for the sustainable development of Greenland.
- considering that a dialogue on natural resources, including raw materials, is of mutual interest and a priority for both sides, due to the role that raw materials can play in the diversification of the Greenlandic economy and the role that Greenland can play as a potential supplier on commercial terms of critical raw materials for the EU in a secured, sustainable and undistorted manner based on free trade principles,
- considering that a dialogue on climate change related issues is of mutual interest,

envisage to further strengthen their relations and cooperation based on broadly shared interests, to the mutual benefit of their peoples, and to endow their mutual relations with a long term perspective.

COMMON OBJECTIVES

The EU and Greenland state their intention to continue and further strengthen their relations and cooperation in the following areas:

- Sustainably managing fish stocks and the marine environment as well as providing fishing opportunities for the vessels of EU Member States which should remain an essential pillar of the partnership between the EU and Greenland and continue to be based on the EU Greenland Fisheries Partnership Agreement⁴ and its Protocols.
- Education and training, tourism and culture.
- Natural resources, including raw materials.
- Energy, climate, environment and biodiversity.
- Arctic issues.
- The social sector; mobility of workforce; social protection systems; food safety and food security issues.
- Research and innovation in areas such as energy, climate change, disaster resilience, natural resources, including raw materials, and sustainable use of living resources.

The European Union states that:

- considering its objectives under the Greenland Treaty, which entered into force on 1 February 1985, and the close and mutually beneficial relations between the European Union and Greenland that has developed since then,
- considering the importance of Greenland as a responsible partner for the management and conservation of the environment and living resources, including fish stocks and the relevance in this context of the Cooperation Agreement between the Ministry of Health in Greenland and the European Environment Agency, signed in Copenhagen, 13 January 2012, to exchange environmental information,
- considering the importance of Greenland as a responsible partner regarding cooperation in strategic areas other than fisheries, such as education and training, tourism and culture, natural resources, including raw materials, energy, climate, environment and biodiversity, Arctic issues, the social sector and research,
- considering the need for capacity-building within the Greenlandic administration to better formulate and implement national policies that will facilitate the sustainable development of Greenland,

⁴ COUNCIL REGULATION (EC) No 753/2007 of 28 June 2007 on the conclusion of the Fisheries Partnership Agreement between the European Community on the one hand, and the Government of Denmark and the Home Rule Government of Greenland, on the other hand

- considering that trade can play an important role in providing full and productive employment and decent work for all, in full respect of the internationally recognised core labour standards, particularly in regards to the exploration and exploitation of natural resources, including raw materials,

it wishes to maintain and strengthen cooperation and dialogue with Greenland on the basis of a partnership based on the Protocol (No. 34) to the Treaty on the European Union on special arrangements for Greenland, the Council Decision on the association of the OCTs with the EU⁵, a Fisheries Partnership Agreement⁶ and of the Council Decision on relations between the EU on the one hand, and Greenland and Denmark on the other⁷.

DEVELOPMENT OF THE PARTNERSHIP

To achieve their common goals and develop their partnership, the relations aim to facilitate consultations and policy dialogue on issues of common interest and any other areas within this declaration.

The sides consider that:

- Greenland's association with the European Union as an Overseas Country and Territory (OCT), as provided for under the Council Decision on the association of the OCTs with the EU and the Council Decision on relations between the EU on the one hand and Greenland and the Kingdom of Denmark on the other, represents an appropriate framework to respond to the specific needs of Greenland and to take into account its very remote location, its extreme climate, as well as its historical and cultural heritage,
- their cooperation may be developed in the areas referred to under the 'Common objectives' that have the potential to contribute to a sustainable development of the economies and to remedy apparent structural problems,

⁵ OJ L 344, 19.12.2013, p. 1; COUNCIL DECISION 2013/755/EU of 25 November 2013 on the association of the overseas countries and territories with the European Union ('Overseas Association Decision').

⁶ Council Regulation (EC) No 753/2007 of 28 June 2007 on the conclusion of the Fisheries Partnership Agreement between the European Community on the one hand, and the Government of Denmark and the Home Rule Government of Greenland, on the other hand.

⁷ OJ L 76, 15.03.2014, p. 1; COUNCIL DECISION 2014/137/EU of 14 March 2014 on relations between the European Union on the one hand, and Greenland and the Kingdom of Denmark on the other.

Both sides share the conviction that their partnership will continue to benefit from the mutual knowledge and understanding acquired through all existing consultative forums and in particular through regular dialogue and consultations, as appropriate.

This Declaration is not intended to create any legal or financial obligations under domestic or international law.

Done at Brussels, on 19 March 2015, in three original copies in the English language.

FOR THE EUROPEAN UNION

FOR THE GOVERNMENT OF
GREENLAND

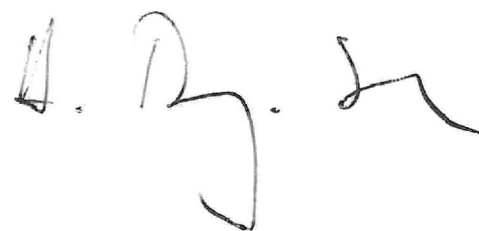
FOR THE GOVERNMENT OF
DENMARK



Jean-Claude JUNCKER
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Commission



Kim KIELSEN
Prime Minister



Helle THORNING-SCHMIDT
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